DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

What Is the Shekhinah?

Daat Tevunot §160

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §160 (section 8, part 4) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 21 September 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are

We are at §160, page 510. So far section 8 has explained the force that sustains this world. When that force is strengthened, it strengthens the emanations that act upon the world (section 7), and when it is weakened, they are weakened. The righteous have the duty to work in partnership with HaKadosh Barukh Hu to strengthen it.

Now the Ramhal asks how this sustaining force relates to the world itself. In doing so, said the Rabbi, he explains things we talk about all the time without really understanding them. What is the Shekhinah? Is it Hashem? Hashem is everywhere, so what do we mean when we say the Shekhinah is stronger at the Kotel?

Like the soul in the body

The Sekhel gives an analogy. A human being is made of body and soul, and the body cannot function without the life force of the soul. To understand the relationship properly, we would have to know how the soul actually moves the body. In the same way, we must now understand how the sustaining force relates to the creatures of this world.

The Kavod Elyon

The Ramhal calls this force the Kavod Elyon, the Supreme Glory, and later the Shekhinah. They are the same thing. The Rabbi was emphatic: the Shekhinah is not Hashem Himself. It is something God created, through simsum, a filtering and diluting of the light, and it is what gives existence to everything in this world. That is what we mean in the Kedushah: "the whole earth is full of His glory."

Sins push this glory away from the lower world. "Your sins separate between you and your God." Good deeds do the opposite: they mashkinim, cause it to dwell, the same root as Shekhinah, which means dwelling. "And I will dwell among them." The more misvot we do, the more the Shekhinah is present and manifest.

The Ramhal brings verses on both sides. Of the nations, Yehoshua and Kalev said "their shelter has departed from them": that shelter is the Kavod. Of the redemption, "the glory of Hashem will shine upon you."

A participant asked whether we can ever cut the connection entirely. The Rabbi answered that we distance the Shekhinah, we "exile" it, but it is always there, otherwise the world would not exist. It is simply not manifest.

The angels and the Kavod

God wants everything to happen through filters, and the malakhim are those filters. They carry the Kavod Elyon within them and bring it into actuality in the world. There is a chain of filtering from the original light, through the angels, to the Shekhinah.

Why some places are holier

Although the Kavod is everywhere, in some places it is more revealed. "To His dwelling you shall seek, and come there." Three times a year "every male shall be seen before the face of Hashem": the face of Hashem is the Shekhinah, more manifest in Yerushalayim and the Beit HaMikdash.

This explains the structure of the Mikdash: a place within a place, further and further in, until the Holy of Holies where the Kavod Elyon is most manifest in the entire universe. That is why the Kohen Gadol entered only once a year with such preparation: special garments, days of separation, and every precaution. There is an upper sanctuary corresponding to the lower one, with the Shekhinah between them.

Yom Kippur and the Kedushah

With Yom Kippur days away, the Rabbi pointed to the long piyyutim about the angels said before the Kedushah: the six angels, the eight angels, the chariots. "Nobody understands it." Why say them there? Because the Kedushah is about the Shekhinah ("Holy, holy, holy... the whole earth is full of His glory"), and the angels are the ones who carry it and try always to elevate it. "Barukh kevod Hashem mimekomo": he connected barukh with berekhah, a pool, something that spreads and flows outward. The angels want the Kavod to spread and be manifest.

He stressed not to confuse this with section 7. The section 7 forces act upon the world; the Shekhinah is the force acting within it.

The Kohanim's role

Each angel and force has its own role within the Shekhinah, and the Kohen Gadol had to have all of this in mind when he served, especially with the daily offering, the tamid. Every detail of the service, the sacrifices, the sprinkling of blood and the incense, held "great secrets" for making the Shekhinah more manifest, on behalf of all Israel and to an extent all humanity.

This is why the Kohanim were held to far stricter standards. A stray thought during the service could invalidate a sacrifice. And it explains why a Kohen with a blemish may not serve. "It's not a disability stigma." If you are bringing perfection into the world, you yourself must be whole. "Nothing personal."

Our role today

Then the Ramhal adds the role of the righteous. Every deficiency in the world comes from God concealing Himself. When His unity is revealed, everything is perfected and the barriers between us are removed. Every good deed reveals something of the unity, which removes what separates us from the Shekhinah and attaches us to the Kavod Elyon, and brings down more blessing.

A participant asked whether the world is getting worse. The Rabbi pushed back: there have always been disasters, plagues killing a third of a population, and "you have to be a great historian" to judge whether now is worse.

The Ramhal brings "Let Him kiss me with the kisses of His mouth": the strong cleaving between God and Israel. As with people who love each other, the closer the connection, the more Hashem wants our service, and the more power He gives us to affect the world.

Summary

- The force of section 8 is the Kavod Elyon, the Shekhinah: not Hashem Himself, but a creation through simsum that gives existence to everything.
- Sins push the Shekhinah away and good deeds cause it to dwell (mashkinim) and become more manifest.
- The angels carry the Shekhinah and work to spread it, which is why we describe them just before the Kedushah.
- The Shekhinah is more revealed in some places, most of all in the Holy of Holies; the Kohanim's exacting service was to strengthen that manifestation.
- Each of us today strengthens the Shekhinah through good deeds, bringing more blessing into the world. "Perfect timing for Yom Kippur."

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